

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

It's time for the interview!



Learning Outcome

Identify and describe jobs and careers in both work and social contexts appropriate for the interlocutor.

Ask your partner:

- Who would you like to do an informational interview with? Why?
- Why do you think it's a good idea to talk to a professional about their job?

Can Do Statements

- I can give descriptions about professional information.
- I can talk about what I was doing in the past.
- I can participate in an informational interview.





Let's Explore!

Kristi meets with Danielle Wilkinson, a former **radio personality***! Is she a **jack-of-all-trades, master of none****?

* A "radio personality" is someone who works on air at a radio station.

** A "jack-of-all-trades, master of none" is a person who is good at many things but not great at anything.

Instructions: Read the text aloud.

- Kristi:** Hello, Ms. Wilkinson. Thank you for agreeing to speak with me. I really think I could benefit from your expertise.
- Danielle:** You're welcome. I know when I was first breaking into the field, I took any advice I could get.
- Kristi:** I couldn't agree more. I really do appreciate having the opportunity to pick your brain.
- Danielle:** Any time. Based on your education I'd say you're already on the right track. Did you join any organizations at Harvard, or were you too busy studying?
- Kristi:** The course load was heavy, of course, but I was writing for the *Harvard Lampoon* in between classes and assignments.
- Danielle:** Good. In your e-mail you mentioned that you were copy editing and that you were publishing content for social media. Is that correct?
- Kristi:** That's correct. On top of that, I was also working with the CEO to develop an offline marketing campaign. I really want to build up my skill set.
- Danielle:** That's great, and there's certainly nothing wrong with learning new skills, but there's something to be said for gaining an in-depth knowledge of one particular area.
- Kristi:** I see what you're saying. I guess the cost of being a jack-of-all-trades is that you're a master of none.
- Danielle:** Exactly. Take me, for example. When I was starting out at WXBJ, I focused on coordinating and scheduling. Sure, I dabbled in talent booking, but I kept my eyes on the main goal.
- Kristi:** I see. So I should spend my efforts developing the skills I hope to use most in the future?
- Danielle:** Exactly.
- Kristi:** Great advice. I'm so glad I met with you!
- Danielle:** Me too.
- Kristi:** Who else would you recommend I speak with?
- Danielle:** There are a few people I would recommend. Why don't I send you an e-mail tomorrow with their names and contact information?
- Kristi:** That would be great! Thank you!





Let's Practice!

What was Danielle doing before she got this gig?

Instructions: Read the dialogue. Select all the phrases that do NOT talk about events that were happening in the past.

- Kristi:** Hello, Ms. Wilkinson. Thank you for agreeing to speak with me. I really think I could benefit from your expertise.
- Danielle:** You're welcome. I know when I was first breaking into the field, I took any advice I could get.
- Kristi:** I couldn't agree more.
- Danielle:** So, did you join any organizations at Harvard, or were you too busy studying?
- Kristi:** The course load was heavy, of course, but I was writing for the Harvard Lampoon in between classes and assignments.
- Danielle:** Good. In your e-mail you mentioned that you were copy editing and that you were publishing content for social media. Is that correct?
- Kristi:** That's correct. On top of that, I was also working with the CEO to develop an offline marketing campaign. I really want to build up my skill set.
- Danielle:** That's great, but there's something to be said for gaining an in-depth knowledge of one particular area.
- Kristi:** I see what you're saying.
- Danielle:** Exactly. Take me, for example. When I was starting out at WXB, I focused on a few different things, but I kept my eyes on the main goal.



Let's Practice!

What do they talk about in the interview?

Instructions: Complete the sentences below by choosing from the words below.

Word Bank

spend your efforts / expertise / marketing campaign / dabbled in talent booking / on the right track / pick your brain / breaking into the field / coordinating and scheduling

1. I think I could benefit from your _____.
2. When I was first _____ I took any advice I could get.
3. I really do appreciate having the opportunity to _____.
4. Based on your education I'd say you're already _____.
5. I worked with the CEO to develop an offline _____.
6. When I started out at WXB, I focused on _____.
7. Sure, I _____, but I kept my eyes on the main goal.
8. You should _____ developing the skills you hope to use most in the future.





Extension Activity

Practice a mock informational interview.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- With a partner, take turns practicing a mock (not real, but intended to be very similar to a real situation) informational interview.
- Practice asking and answering questions. Remember to use the Simple Past and the Past Continuous tenses.
- Refer to the tips about interview etiquette on the last page.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I participate in an informational interview.

☐ ☐

I give descriptions to my partner about professional information.

☐ ☐

I talk about what I was doing in the past.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- expertise** (noun): an ability or strength a person develops through practice and education
e.g. I really think I could benefit from your expertise.
- to pick your brain** (expression): to ask questions of someone who is more knowledgeable on a topic
e.g. I really do appreciate having the opportunity to pick your brain.
- on the right track** (expression): acting in a way where you are likely to achieve the results you want
e.g. I'd say you're already on the right track.
- to coordinate** (verb): to organize an activity so that the people involved in it work well together
e.g. When I was starting out at WXB, I focused on coordinating and scheduling.
- to schedule** (verb): to plan that something will happen at a particular time
e.g. When I was starting out at WXB, I focused on coordinating and scheduling.
- to dabble in** (verb): to do something in a way that is not very serious
e.g. Then, I dabbled in a few things here and there.
- talent booking** (noun): the process of finding people with a special ability to do something well
e.g. I did talent booking for a while, but I always kept my eyes on the main goal.





Learning Points

The Simple Past and The Past Continuous Tenses

When you are in an interview, it is common to use a mixture of tenses. They allow you to convey a variety of timelines and action sequences.

You use the **Simple Past** tense to talk past events that are short, for longer situations or for repeated events.

You use the **Past Continuous** tense to talk about:

- two or more actions in the past; one continues for a period, and the other starts and ends in the past (simple past).

For example: **When** *I was first getting started in the broadcast industry, I talked to many different people.*

- two or more actions in the past, both happening over a period of time.

For example: *I was studying and I was working in retail.*

- a temporary activity that takes place over a limited time.

For example: *I was writing for them during the semester.*

The form of the **Past Continuous** is:

subject + was/were + verb-ing

NOTE: When you want to ask a question using the **Past Continuous**, the form changes.
Was/were + subject + verb-ing ... ?

For example:

Were you busy studying for your tests?





Learning Points

Informational Interview Etiquette

Here are some tips about what you should do in an informational interview.

1. **Treat the meeting like it is a real interview.** *Arrive on time and dress like you would for a traditional interview.*
1. **Prepare 5 to 10 questions.** *Ask about the interviewer's experience at the company and how it has changed. Discuss what they like best about their job and what are some challenges. Ask for suggestions and advice for your own career.*
1. **Be pleasant.** *Even if the interviewer's advice does not seem appropriate, thank them for it anyway.*
1. **Ask for permission if you want to take notes.** *When you take notes, you demonstrate that you are listening carefully to what the person is saying.*
1. **Ask the names of the interviewer's close colleagues.** *Ask for recommendations of people you can meet. Take note of these names and ask if you can mention the interviewer's name when contacting them.*
1. **Don't abuse your interviewer's busy time.** *Limit the interview to 30 minutes, unless he or she expresses a willingness to spend more time with you.*
1. **Thank the interviewer at the start and the end of the interview.** *It is a sign of respect and appreciation for their investment of time.*

